

MOTORCYCLES

SIMPLIFY, THEN ADD LIGHTNESS

THE NEW R 1300 GS IS COLIN CHAPMAN'S PHILOSOPHY IN ACTION, WHICH MAKES THE GS HOLISTICALLY MORE ACCESSIBLE AND FRIENDLIER

BY DIPAYAN DUTTA

BMW R 1300 GS

BMW's new flagship GS—the R 1300 GS—is here. With this, the company has retained the core competency requirements while also redefining the GS under three base principles—making it compact, lighter and simplified.

The first taste of this philosophy is the design. The function is simple, making it lighter, more compact and less intimidating. The headlight is setting the tone for what is an otherwise diminutive relative to the bike's previous generation. It looks smaller, more compact and in that right, friendlier. The beaky front has been retained but it's less bulky and svelte. The most defining feature is still the big displacement boxer, but now, if you look at it head-on, the left and right cylinders are symmetric. The windscreen is now electrically adjustable and it does a more than commendable job of blocking windblasts even if you're above 6-foot tall. Drop it lower, and it's much easier to see where you're going in the corners. And the best bit of it happens on the go, and at whatever speed.

Despite its diminished proportions, being 12kg (!) lighter, narrower and less imposing, the seat height has remained the same at 85mm. One gets the sense that all this compacting has raised the centre of gravity, making it feel slightly more top-heavy and cumbersome to handle at speed. To compensate, the Triple Black version gets a ride height system (Adaptive Ride Height) that drops 30mm as speeds drop below the 30kmph mark. It resets once you breach 50kmph, meaning you don't lose any of the off-road capability or that field of vision.

This new frame manages the weight —237kg—and forces so well that the R 1300 floats through switchbacks with swift deftness. This is in equal parts the chassis as well as the heavily reworked suspension. At the front, the iconic Telelevers are still intact, but now they too are heavily reworked. A reinforcement now makes the connection between the bar and the forks up front more rigid, sending more feedback to the rider and making it easier to feel your way through a corner. The brakes are pretty good, but you wish for a stronger initial bite. The ride is comfortable to a point where it's hard to tell the reality of the surface you are on.

BMW R 1300 GS
Engine: 1,300cc, boxer-twin
Power: 145bhp@7,750rpm
Torque: 149Nm@6,500rpm
Price: ₹20.95 lakh (ex-showroom, pan-India)
On sale now

On to the centrepiece, the big block boxer has become the most recognisable motor configuration in the adventure space. Yes, including the V4. The way it delivers power is just incredible because, usually, you have low-down power that tapers out towards the end of the band, but the R 1300 has so much of both that it just keeps going.

There's a new gearbox too, with a new quick shifter that is much more effective than before. Overall, this GS has added to its toolkit with better road prowess and much more performance in the accessible range. ■